PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mitsubishi Delica Star Wagon (L300 4WD)

1986–1999 · P25W · P35W · P24W · P23W

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust is the deal-breaker**
  Every buyer's guide and forum thread says the same thing: buy the rust-free van, not the one with the better engine. Check the pinch welds along the bottom of the body, the box sections behind the front steps, under the sliding-door step and the rear corners, then the windscreen pillars and roof gutters, which a Delica.ca veteran says are usually the first to go. A bubble outside means far more inside.

- [ ] **Pull up the carpets**
  Wet footwells are a known L300 problem. Water gets in through the front panel seams above the headlamps, the windscreen seal, gutter seams, the antenna base and the washer jets, and one owner found his driver's floor and a seat-mount bolt rusted through from underneath. Feel the carpet and look for that 'wet dog' smell.

- [ ] **Crystal Lite and high roofs**
  GearJunkie warns that Crystal Lite glass roofs are more prone to leaks and rust, and Delica.ca has threads about rusty roofs on 1993 Crystal Lite vans. Check every glass panel seal and the gutters, and look at the roof from a ladder.

- [ ] **Ask about the head and the belts**
  Head gaskets and cracked heads are the 4D56's known weakness in this van, usually after overheating. Ask for records of the timing belt, balance-shaft belt and water pump. Watch the temperature gauge on a long climb, look for bubbles or pressure in the coolant overflow and check for white smoke.

- [ ] **Test 2H, 4H and 4L, and both hubs**
  Engage 4H and 4L and drive on loose ground to make sure both front hubs actually lock. One Delica.ca member points out that the clunk of engagement doesn't prove both hubs are working. Automatic hubs need cleaning and greasing, and a seized one is a common find.

- [ ] **Don't trust the LSD sticker**
  A limited-slip rear diff was standard on some grades, and many vans have a door-jamb LSD sticker. Forum members warn that stickers go missing and appear on vans without an LSD. Jack up one rear wheel and spin it: if the other wheel turns the same way, it's a limited slip.

- [ ] **Check the paperwork and your state**
  Get the import entry documents (CBP and EPA forms) and a clean title. Then confirm your state will register it. Maine revoked Delica registrations in 2021 and Michigan sent owners letters in 2024. Crankshaft Culture also says many mainstream insurers won't cover a Delica at an agreed value, so get a quote first.

- [ ] **Drive it like it'll be driven**
  A healthy 4D56 is slow but should pull cleanly without heavy black smoke or a clattery 'tractor' noise at idle. That noise can mean a timing belt that has jumped a tooth. On automatics, a harsh 1–2 shift under power can mean a blocked filter screen, and a missing kickdown action can mean a broken kickdown cable.

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Frame number**
  Stamped plate under a plastic cover between the driver's seat and the door, reading P25W or P35W followed by the serial. Enter it into a Mitsubishi parts catalogue (Megazip, Amayama) to see the exact build, engine and parts.
- [ ] **Chassis code**
  4WD vans: P23W (2.0 petrol, to 1989), P24W (2.4 petrol, from 1989), P25W (diesel, Aero Roof or sunroof) and P35W (diesel, High Roof or Crystal Lite Roof). P03W, P04W, P05W and P15W are two-wheel-drive Star Wagons.
- [ ] **Model-code prefix**
  Japanese catalogues add an emissions prefix that dates the diesel: N-P25W (1986–88), Q-P25W/P35W (1988 to mid-1993), Y-P25W/P35W (from mid-1993), and KD-P25W/P35W on late vans (seen by 1997).
- [ ] **Roof**
  Aero Roof vans are 1,975 mm tall and High Roof vans 2,090 mm. Crystal Lite Roof vans have a high roof with glass panels; check every seal.
- [ ] **Special editions**
  Chamonix and Jasper vans carry side graphics and embroidered seat backs. GearJunkie says they added waterproof carpet, dual batteries and a rear LSD. Verify against the frame-number lookup, because graphics are easy to add.
- [ ] **Limited-slip diff**
  Don't trust the door-jamb LSD sticker. Lift one rear wheel and spin it: if the other wheel turns the same way, it's a limited slip; if it turns the opposite way, it's open.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/delica/delica-l300/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks